

Research Design 2026 — next steps

Francisco Villamil

Updated 13 September 2026

Next steps

Updated 2026-09-10. Session 1 is Tue Sep 15 (5 days). Sessions: Sep 15, 22, 29, Oct 6, 13. Workshop Mon Oct 26. Essay due Tue Oct 27.

Session 1 is **ready**: deck, notes version, teaching guide, and the 2026 syllabus are all built and compile clean. What follows is everything still outstanding.

Settled — no action needed

- **Essay deadline Oct 27** confirmed against the exam calendar.
- **Group formation**: no separate deadline. Whoever submits **Memo 5 together (Mon Oct 19)** is a group, and that grouping is binding for the presentation and the essay. In the syllabus and on the workshop slide.
- **The two worked examples** (hotel bookings, Spotify) are labelled just “examples” on the slides. Mention on the spot that they are real theses or course projects, without naming anyone.
- **Charlie Kirk stays** as the session-2 running example for now. Revisit later; the slot is marked % SWAPPABLE: so the structure survives a swap.
- **Memos get no written feedback**. Questions in class are welcome, and raising things that struck you while reading them is fine, but nothing formal and nothing announced.
- Aula Global assignments set up; syllabus PDF pushed.

The content budget (corrected)

The paper discussion is **~25 minutes, not half the session**. An earlier version of this plan assumed 45-50, which under-filled session 2 by about 20 minutes before it was fixed. The real budget for a lecture session:

```
180 slot
-12 arrival / settling
-10 break
-25 paper discussion
-13 close, memo brief, questions
---
120 minutes of lecture content
```

At roughly 2-2.5 min per frame with a couple of pair exercises, that is **about 55-60 frames including section roadmaps**. Session 1 (no paper) has more time and runs 69. Session 2 now runs 59. **Build sessions 3-5 against 120 minutes, not 100.**

Each deck should carry a little more than fits, with a short “if you are running behind” list in its teaching notes, rather than a little less.

Before each session — the decks

Only session 1 exists so far. Each new deck goes in `reframing_2026/slides/`, built from `08_outline_2026.md` and adjusted for how the previous session actually went.

By Sep 22 — session 2, “Questions and data” — BUILT

`slides/2_questions_and_data/` — 50 frames, compiles clean. Block A (topic → question, theory, mechanisms, levels of explanation moved here) + the new provenance block (ready-made/custommade, Salganik’s ten characteristics, Xbox, Google Flu, algorithmic confounding, post-API, dirty and sensitive) + a structured paper discussion and the Memo 2 brief.

Expanded 2026-09-11 from 50 to 59 frames after correcting the paper-discussion budget: restored the “Research and RQs” recap and the Mahou exercise in Block A, added “Incomplete”, and added a new practical block (where data actually lives, what a codebook gives you, what a real data file looks like, and a six-question checklist before committing to a source).

- ☐ **Two figures still missing**, both marked % TODO: in `questions_body.tex`. The frames work without them, so this is an improvement rather than a blocker:
 - the **CDC vs GFT** over-prediction time series (Google Flu)
 - the **Xbox** demographic-skew bar chart and forecast-vs-outcome plot
- ☒ **Done** - teaching notes for session 2 (`teaching_notes_session2.pdf`, 10pp).

By Sep 29 — session 3, “Measurement and description”

- ☐ Assemble from the existing back half of `basics_quant_data.tex` (mostly exists, just needs room)
- ☐ Add classifier-output-as-a-variable, using the Barberá images already in `img/`
- ☐ Add Obermeyer proxy failure; expand the description block with Chetty and culturomics
- ☐ Source figures: Obermeyer cost-vs-illness, an Opportunity Insights map, n-gram + corpus composition

By Oct 6 — session 4, “Causality” (cheapest week, mostly deletion)

- ☐ Trim `causality.tex` 91 → ~55 frames; PO example 8 → 5; Off topic: Controlling 4 → 1
- ☐ Restore the commented-out **prediction** frames (1–2, since the triad carries the load now)
- ☐ Add platform experiments and their limits (Guess + Bail), and interference-as-normal-in-CSS
- ☐ Source the Bail treatment-effect-by-party figure

By Oct 13 — session 5, “Designs and credibility”

- ☐ **Cut Causal methods again, in detail** (~65 frames) to `slides/appendix_methods_detail/`. Move, don’t delete
- ☐ Merge `causal_inference.tex` block A with the first ~45 frames of `advanced.tex`
- ☐ Compress meta-analysis 10 → 5; move synthetic control to the appendix
- ☐ Build the credibility block (forking paths, Breznau, pre-registration) and the ethics block
- ☐ Build the closing prediction-revisited frames (Fragile Families) and the return to the triad
- ☐ Present **Villamil & Balcells** as your own worked DiD, including what you’d do differently
- ☐ Source figures: Breznau distribution-of-estimates, Fragile Families scatter

By Oct 23 — workshop materials

- ☐ Pair the groups once Memo 5 is in (Oct 19), and circulate each sketch to its partner
 - ☐ Write the peer-review sheet (written comments, handed in, graded on the group)
 - ☐ Slot schedule: ~12 slots, 12 min + 8 min, hard stop
 - ☐ Required-slides list, including “**the threat I can’t solve**”
-

Carried over

- ☒ **Done** - 40-student pass on the session-1 teaching notes. Think-pair-share replaces “let silences sit” at the variation block, the three unit-of-analysis graphs are now a show of hands, and a general note on method was added to the front of the guide.
- ☐ **Teaching notes for sessions 3–5.** Sessions 1 and 2 have them.
- ☐ **Em-dash pass on the plan docs.** Done for the syllabus, both decks, and both teaching guides (which now share a heading style). Still outstanding: ~143 in `08_outline_2026.md` and scattered through the other plan files. These are internal working documents, so this is cosmetic.
- ☐ **Decide when the new decks replace `res_design/slides/`.** The old decks are untouched and still what `index.md` would link to.
- ☐ **`index.md`:** add slide PDF links as each deck is finished.
- ☒ **Done** — Aula Global course ID in the website sidebar, now `id=208247`. Sidebar year fixed to 2026, schedule table reduced to 13px.

Housekeeping

- ☐ Adopt the two-wrapper notes pattern in decks 2–5 as they are built (session 1 already has it; `slides/beamer_notes_preamble.tex` exists and is reusable).
- ☐ Build artifacts (`.aux`, `.nav`, `.snm`, `.toc`, `.fdb_latexmk`, `.synctex.gz`) are cluttering both slide trees, and there is a stray `files/survivorship_bias_copy.png`. **Ask before deleting**, and check `.gitignore` covers them going forward.